

A FREE COMPANION RESOURCE FROM FOUNDATIONS & HORIZONS

STRONG FOUNDATIONS, HIGHER HORIZONS

Leadership Discussion Guide

For nonprofit leadership teams, boards, book clubs, and professional-development cohorts

Built to be used, not just read.

Eight practical conversations that help teams turn the ideas in Stephen Cook's Strong Foundations, Higher Horizons into clearer priorities, healthier systems, and concrete next steps.

Stephen Cook • Foundations & Horizons

Building Strong Foundations. Guiding Towards New Horizons.

Welcome

Strong Foundations, Higher Horizons was written for nonprofit leaders who are doing meaningful work while carrying more than any one person should have to carry. This guide is designed to help a group slow down long enough to talk about what the book reveals about its own organization - and then do something useful with that conversation.

A note from real-world use

One nonprofit leader who used the book for a staff study reported that it was “hands down the most relatable book we have done so far,” and that staff were already referring back to its ideas in everyday conversations. That is the goal here: not perfect answers, but useful language, shared insight, and better decisions.

How to Use This Guide

- Plan for 45-75 minutes per session. The conversation matters more than finishing every question.
- Assign the reading in advance. Ask everyone to bring one passage, story, or idea that felt especially familiar.
- Choose a facilitator, but do not make the facilitator the expert. Their job is to keep the conversation moving and make space for honest reflection.
- Talk about your real organization. Avoid staying safely theoretical.
- End every session with one small commitment. Progress beats a beautiful list of ideas nobody owns.
- Use the Leadership Toolkit in the book when a session points to a practical next step. The guide intentionally complements those tools rather than recreating them.

A Simple Facilitation Rhythm

5-10 min	What stood out? Start with Sarah's story and the moments that felt familiar.
20-30 min	Discuss the questions that matter most to your group.
15-20 min	Apply the idea directly to your organization.
5-10 min	Choose one action, owner, or experiment.
Next meeting	Briefly check what happened before moving into the next topic.

The Eight-Session Path

1. Professionalism Without Heroics — Introduction + Chapters 1-2

- 2. Focus Before More** — Chapters 3-4
- 3. Measure, Plan, Execute** — Chapters 5-7
- 4. Systems and Capacity** — Chapters 8-9
- 5. Credibility and Better Tools** — Chapters 10-11
- 6. Stronger Together, Sustainable Together** — Chapters 12-14
- 7. Protect the Mission, Challenge the Myths** — Chapter 15 + Bonus Chapter
- 8. Build the Next 90 Days** — Chapter 16 + Final Thoughts + Leadership Toolkit

FOUNDATION ONE

Session 1: Professionalism Without Heroics

Before You Meet

Read: Introduction: For the Leaders Wearing Every Hat; Chapter 1: Nonprofit Doesn't Mean Non-Professional; Chapter 2: Be the CEO, Not the Chief Everything Officer
Come ready to name one moment that felt familiar in your own organization.

Why This Conversation Matters

Passion matters, but passion cannot substitute for structure. This session asks the group to examine the difference between being deeply committed and being unnecessarily dependent on a few people doing everything.

Start With the Story

Open with a simple question: Which moment from Sarah and BrightPath made you laugh, wince, or think, “That is us”? Use the story to get people talking before moving into solutions.

Talk It Through

1. Where did you recognize your organization in Sarah's first days at BrightPath?
2. When we say “professional,” what should that mean for our organization - and what should it not mean?
3. Which parts of our work currently depend on someone remembering, rescuing, or personally carrying the task?
4. Where is a leader on our team acting as the Chief Everything Officer? What is that costing the organization?
5. What would become possible if leadership time shifted from constant reaction toward direction, coaching, and decision-making?
6. What is one thing we tolerate because “we're a nonprofit” that we would never accept if we believed strong operations were part of the mission?

Look at Your Organization: The Hero Test

Choose three recurring responsibilities that currently depend heavily on one person. For each, discuss what would happen if that person were unavailable for two weeks.

- What knowledge exists only in someone's head?
- What decision could be delegated with clearer guardrails?
- What simple process or checklist would reduce dependence on heroic effort?

Use the Book's Toolkit

Use Tool 4: Delegation Planner when the conversation identifies work that should move to another person. Do not delegate chaos; clarify the outcome, authority, resources, and check-in first.

Before You Meet Again

Choose one responsibility to clarify, document, or delegate before the next session. Name the owner and the smallest useful next step.

FOUNDATION TWO

Session 2: Focus Before More

Before You Meet

Read: Chapter 3: You Can't Feed the World, and That's Okay; Chapter 4: Strategic Planning Isn't Just for Retreats

Come ready to name one moment that felt familiar in your own organization.

Why This Conversation Matters

Good opportunities can still be wrong opportunities. Strategy is the discipline of deciding what matters now - and protecting enough attention and capacity to actually do it.

Start With the Story

Open with a simple question: Which moment from Sarah and BrightPath made you laugh, wince, or think, “That is us”? Use the story to get people talking before moving into solutions.

Talk It Through

1. Where are we currently trying to serve too many priorities, audiences, programs, or ideas at once?
2. Which opportunities are hardest for us to say no to? Why?
3. Does our strategic plan influence weekly decisions, or mostly live in a document?
4. What are the three most important outcomes for our organization right now?
5. What are we doing because it is genuinely strategic, and what are we doing because it has always been done?
6. What would we stop, pause, or postpone if we treated capacity as real?

Look at Your Organization: The Not-Now List

Create two columns: “Essential Now” and “Good, But Not Now.” Move at least one real initiative, idea, or request into the second column.

- Does it directly advance the mission?
- Do we have the capacity to do it well?
- What would we have to delay or weaken to say yes?

Use the Book's Toolkit

Use Tool 3: Mission Filter Checklist for a current opportunity or idea. The goal is not to reject ambition; it is to make room for the right ambition.

Before You Meet Again

Agree on one priority the team will protect and one thing the team will intentionally not pursue during the next planning cycle.

FOUNDATION THREE

Session 3: Measure, Plan, Execute

Before You Meet

Read: Chapter 5: Metrics Without Meaning; Chapter 6: The 12-Week Year - Planning That Actually Gets Done; Chapter 7: OKRs - The Framework That Makes Things Happen
Come ready to name one moment that felt familiar in your own organization.

Why This Conversation Matters

Data, planning, and goals should help people make decisions. When they become reporting rituals, they create work without creating clarity. This session connects meaningful measures to short-cycle execution.

Start With the Story

Open with a simple question: Which moment from Sarah and BrightPath made you laugh, wince, or think, “That is us”? Use the story to get people talking before moving into solutions.

Talk It Through

1. Which numbers do we track because they actually guide decisions? Which do we track because someone once asked for them?
2. What important outcome do we care about but currently measure poorly?
3. Where do annual goals lose momentum between planning meetings?
4. Would a 12-week planning cycle make any current priority more manageable? Which one?
5. Can everyone on the team explain what success looks like for our top priorities?
6. Where are we measuring activity when we really need to measure outcome?

Look at Your Organization: From Activity to Outcome

Take one current priority and write down the activities you perform, the output they create, and the outcome you actually want. Then identify the smallest set of measures that would tell you whether the work is succeeding.

- What decision would this measure help us make?
- Who needs to see it, and how often?
- What can we stop tracking if it is not useful?

Use the Book's Toolkit

Use Tool 1: 12-Week Sprint Planner and Tool 2: OKR Worksheet. Pick one priority, not ten. Define the objective, measurable results, and the weekly actions that move it.

Before You Meet Again

Draft one 12-week objective with no more than three key results. Assign an owner and decide when progress will be reviewed.

FOUNDATION FOUR

Session 4: Systems and Capacity

Before You Meet

Read: Chapter 8: You Can't Scale Chaos; Chapter 9: Capacity Is a Boundary, Not a Bad Word
Come ready to name one moment that felt familiar in your own organization.

Why This Conversation Matters

Growth magnifies whatever already exists. Strong systems make good work repeatable; honest capacity limits keep growth from becoming organizational self-harm.

Start With the Story

Open with a simple question: Which moment from Sarah and BrightPath made you laugh, wince, or think, “That is us”? Use the story to get people talking before moving into solutions.

Talk It Through

1. What process currently works only because a particular person knows how to make it work?
2. Where do we repeatedly solve the same problem from scratch?
3. If demand increased by 25% next month, what would break first?
4. Where are we confusing willingness with capacity?
5. What signals tell us that a team, program, or process is at its limit?
6. Where would a boundary protect quality, people, or mission impact?

Look at Your Organization: The Fragility Map

Identify one high-impact process and walk through it from start to finish. Mark every point where the process depends on memory, a workaround, a single person, or an unclear handoff.

- What is the most fragile step?
- What could be standardized without becoming bureaucratic?
- What capacity limit should be made explicit?

Use the Book's Toolkit

Use Tool 5: Capacity Map to compare what your organization is currently carrying with the people, time, systems, and resources available to carry it.

Before You Meet Again

Choose one recurring process to document or simplify, and one capacity boundary the team will communicate more clearly.



FOUNDATION FIVE

Session 5: Credibility and Better Tools

Before You Meet

Read: Chapter 10: Your Look Is Your Reputation; Chapter 11: New Chapter, New Tools
Come ready to name one moment that felt familiar in your own organization.

Why This Conversation Matters

People form judgments about an organization's capacity before they ever see the work behind the scenes. Professional presence and fit-for-purpose tools reduce friction, build trust, and help strong programs look as credible as they really are.

Start With the Story

Open with a simple question: Which moment from Sarah and BrightPath made you laugh, wince, or think, “That is us”? Use the story to get people talking before moving into solutions.

Talk It Through

1. What does someone experience in the first ten minutes of interacting with our organization?
2. Where might outdated, inconsistent, or unclear materials unintentionally weaken trust?
3. What part of our external presence best reflects the quality of our work? What part least reflects it?
4. Which tool, spreadsheet, binder, inbox, or workaround creates the most friction today?
5. Are we keeping any system because it is familiar rather than because it is effective?
6. How do we introduce better tools without creating change fatigue?

Look at Your Organization: The Friction Walk

Imagine you are a new donor, volunteer, partner, staff member, or client. Walk through one common interaction from their point of view and note every place they might feel confused, delayed, or uncertain.

- What can be fixed in under an hour?
- What needs a better process before it needs better technology?
- What tool change would save meaningful time or reduce errors?

Use the Book's Toolkit

The book's toolkit does not prescribe a technology stack. Use the principles in this session to choose tools that fit your actual size, capacity, and workflow - and to retire tools that no longer serve the work.

Before You Meet Again

Make one credibility improvement and one friction-reduction improvement. Keep both small enough to finish before the next session.

FOUNDATION SIX

Session 6: Stronger Together, Sustainable Together

Before You Meet

Read: Chapter 12: Collaboration over Competition; Chapter 13: Burnout Isn't a Badge of Honor; Chapter 14: Fundraising Is Everyone's Job - Sort Of
Come ready to name one moment that felt familiar in your own organization.

Why This Conversation Matters

Healthy organizations do not operate as islands, martyrs, or fundraising departments with programs attached. Collaboration, sustainable leadership, and a shared culture of stewardship reinforce one another.

Start With the Story

Open with a simple question: Which moment from Sarah and BrightPath made you laugh, wince, or think, “That is us”? Use the story to get people talking before moving into solutions.

Talk It Through

1. Where do we treat another organization as a competitor when collaboration might create more impact?
2. What could we share, coordinate, refer, or build together without weakening our identity?
3. What behaviors in our culture unintentionally reward exhaustion or overwork?
4. How easy is it for someone here to say, “I do not have capacity for that”?
5. What role should staff, board members, volunteers, and leaders each play in creating a culture that supports fundraising?
6. Do people throughout the organization understand the story of our impact well enough to talk about it naturally?

Look at Your Organization: The Sustainability Conversation

Draw three headings: Partnerships, People, and Stewardship. Under each, name one strength and one risk in the current organization.

- Who is one organization we could collaborate with more intentionally?
- What burnout signal have we normalized?
- What would help more people become confident ambassadors for the mission?

Use the Book's Toolkit

Use Tool 6: Burnout Self-Check individually or as a private reflection. The purpose is not diagnosis; it is

noticing patterns early enough to change how work is designed.

Before You Meet Again

Choose one action that strengthens a relationship and one action that makes the work more sustainable for the people doing it.

FOUNDATION SEVEN

Session 7: Protect the Mission, Challenge the Myths

Before You Meet

Read: Chapter 15: When the Mission Creeps In; Bonus Chapter: Nonprofit Leadership Myths (And the Truth That Sets You Free)

Come ready to name one moment that felt familiar in your own organization.

Why This Conversation Matters

Mission drift rarely arrives looking reckless. It often looks generous, urgent, fundable, or exciting. This session examines the beliefs and pressures that make organizations say yes when leadership should create clarity.

Start With the Story

Open with a simple question: Which moment from Sarah and BrightPath made you laugh, wince, or think, “That is us”? Use the story to get people talking before moving into solutions.

Talk It Through

1. What kind of opportunity is most likely to pull us away from our core mission?
2. Have we ever kept a program, partnership, or practice because stopping it felt harder than questioning it?
3. Which nonprofit leadership myth in the bonus chapter is easiest for us to believe?
4. Where does sacrifice get confused with effectiveness in our culture?
5. How do funding opportunities influence our definition of what belongs inside the mission?
6. What would we need to believe differently in order to lead more intentionally?

Look at Your Organization: A Mission Audit

Choose one current program or initiative and evaluate it without defending it. Ask whether it still belongs, whether it produces meaningful impact, and what it costs in capacity.

- Does this make the mission stronger - or just busier?
- If we were designing the organization today, would we add this?
- What evidence would justify continuing, changing, partnering, pausing, or ending it?

Use the Book's Toolkit

Return to Tool 3: Mission Filter Checklist. This time, use it on something already inside the organization rather than a new opportunity.

Before You Meet Again

Identify one assumption the team wants to challenge and one program, practice, or opportunity that deserves a more deliberate decision.

HIGHER HORIZONS

Session 8: Build the Next 90 Days

Before You Meet

Read: Chapter 16: Strong Foundations, Higher Horizons; Final Thoughts; Leadership Toolkit
Come ready to name one moment that felt familiar in your own organization.

Why This Conversation Matters

The book ends with a practical challenge: strong organizations are built through clarity, systems, capacity, adaptation, and sustainable leadership. The final session turns the group's conversations into a short, realistic action plan.

Start With the Story

Open with a simple question: Which moment from Sarah and BrightPath made you laugh, wince, or think, “That is us”? Use the story to get people talking before moving into solutions.

Talk It Through

1. Looking back across the book, where are our foundations strongest?
2. Where are we most fragile?
3. What idea from the book has shown up most often in our conversations?
4. What has already changed because we read and discussed this together?
5. If we could improve only one operational area over the next 90 days, which improvement would create the most leverage?
6. What do we need to stop doing so the chosen priority has a real chance to succeed?

Final Exercise: Strong Foundations Assessment

Rate the organization from 1 (fragile) to 5 (strong) in each area below. Do not debate the exact number for too long; use differences in ratings to find the conversation.

- Strategic clarity
- Leadership roles and delegation
- Meaningful measures
- Planning and execution
- Repeatable systems
- Capacity and boundaries
- Professional presence
- Tools and workflow

- Collaboration
- Team sustainability
- Fundraising culture
- Mission focus

Use the Book's Toolkit

Choose whichever Leadership Toolkit resource best supports the priority you select. The toolkit is there to help turn the conversation into action, not to create more paperwork.

Before You Meet Again

Complete the 90-Day Action Plan on the next page. Keep it focused enough that the team can actually finish it.

FROM DISCUSSION TO ACTION

90-Day Action Plan

One meaningful improvement, completed well, is more valuable than twelve good intentions.

Our 90-day priority

What is the single most important operational improvement we will make?

Why this matters

What problem will it solve or what capacity will it create?

Success will look like

What will be measurably or observably different at the end of 90 days?

Owner

Who is responsible for keeping this moving?

Key actions

What are the 3-5 major actions required?

What we will stop or defer

What will we intentionally not do so this priority has room?

Check-in rhythm

When will we review progress?

Facilitator Notes

The strongest conversations will not always be the most comfortable ones. A few reminders can keep the group productive:

- Ask for examples. “Where do we see that here?” is often more useful than another abstract opinion.
- Do not let one person become the organization's narrator. Invite different roles and perspectives.
- Separate diagnosis from blame. A fragile process is a design problem to improve, not evidence that someone failed.
- Capture decisions and owners. Insight without ownership disappears quickly.
- Do not force consensus on every observation. Differences in perception are useful data.
- Protect the book's spirit: progress over perfection. The goal is a stronger organization, not a perfect score.

A good closing question for every session

What is one thing we want to remember from this conversation when the pressure of normal work returns tomorrow?

For Boards and Mixed Leadership Groups

If board members and staff are using the guide together, keep governance and management roles clear. Board members can help clarify mission, priorities, risk, sustainability, and accountability without turning the discussion into day-to-day management. Staff can bring operational reality without feeling that every problem raised is a performance critique.

For Leadership Cohorts

If participants come from different organizations, replace “our organization” with “your organization” during exercises. Encourage participants to share patterns and lessons without disclosing confidential information. The diversity of organizations can become an advantage: participants often see one another's challenges more clearly than their own.

Keep Building

The purpose of this guide is not to finish a book study. It is to help a group build shared language for stronger nonprofit leadership and turn that language into better operating choices.

Strong foundations are not about perfection.

They are about stability - the kind that gives an organization room to reach higher.

Use the free leadership and operations tools available from Foundations & Horizons alongside the book. If this guide helped your team, share it with another nonprofit leader who could use it.

Free companion resource

This Leadership Discussion Guide is designed to accompany Strong Foundations, Higher Horizons: A Leader's Guide to Nonprofit Success by Stephen Cook. It is provided free by Foundations & Horizons so organizations can put the ideas to work without purchasing an additional workbook.

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